THE NEW POLL STAR

'Ilaya Thalapathi' Vijay throws his hat in the political ring. Can he do what Rajini, Kamal couldn't—break the Dravidian hegemony?



^ **NEW CONTENDER** Vijay unveils the TVK flag

On September 8, Tamil superstar Vijay announced that the "first door had been opened" with the Election Commission recognising his party, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). The 50-year-old actor, who has a humongous following in the southern states, has said he is quitting movies to concentrate full-time on politics. The big question is: will he contest the 2026 election and can he make an impact?

Tamil Nadu's entrenched Dravidian politics is littered with actors who wanted to "make a difference" but fell by the wayside. 'Thaliavar' Rajinikanth kickstarted his venture, Rajini Makkal Mandram, in 2018 by rallying his fan clubs but that didn't even make it past the farm gates. 'Ulaganayagan' Kamal Haasan went a step further, with his Makkal Needhi Maiam contesting the elections in 2019 (Lok Sabha) and 2021 (assembly) but came up empty. He has finally hitched his wagon to the DMK-led alliance with the promise of an RS term in return.

As for the 'Ilaya Thalapathi (Young General)', he has a huge following among women but converting them to TVK voters will not be easy as they are largely committed to the DMK (Stalin's slew of women-centric schemes has helped). "Lack of experience and a complete absence of political credibility are big disadvantages for the TVK," says analyst Ramu Manivannan.

A bright move for him could be to promise total prohibition, like N.T. Rama Rao did in the 1980s, and convince voters that he is serious about it. But for that Vijay will have to shake off his filmy image for voters to accept him as a serious politician. That tactic worked for the late Vijayakanth with his Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam in the 2006 assembly poll when his do-gooder offscreen image coupled with the Dravidian tag in the party name worked wonders in a few areas. But even he fizzled out very soon.

In Vijay's case, such sociopolitical tropes are eclipsed by the commercial in his big budget films. He is among the highest paid actors in India today but still has little to show for philanthropy. His latest release, *G.O.A.T.*, came out in September and is a hit (it landed him a Rs 200 crore pay cheque). His purported last film, *Thalapathy 69*, is on the floors now.

party, the AIADMK would stand a fair chance of doing well. "The AIADMK under EPS is only just recovering from the setbacks in elections. It may not have the same stamina of the 2021 assembly election. That said, shrewd and subtle shifts with strategic alliance formations could change the course for the party," adds Manivannan.

If the campaign becomes BJP-centric, an idea that the DMK would be only too happy to promote, then the latter stands to gain. "If the anti-BJP element continues to dominate the discourse in 2026, which in part is the saffron party leadership's own doing, it will be advantage DMK," says Moorthy. Indeed, right now such is the antipathy that despite parting ways with the saffron side in this year's Lok Sabha election, the AIADMK remains suspect in the eyes of Dravidian voters.

It is abundantly clear that somewhere along the way, state president Annamalai and the BJP have lost the momentum. They need to re-align with the local idiom to make progress. "The nationwide sanatana dharma campaign and the targeting of Udhayanidhi since last September provided little returns in the Lok Sabha election. There are lessons in this that the state BJP must learn," says Moorthy. The ruling DMK will be hoping no such thing happens. ■